If the Timurid ladies were horrified at the blasphemous disrespect shown to the Prophet and Islam, then the Rajput wives would have found equally intolerable the repeated suggestion by the Jesuits that Akbar distance himself from all but one wife. '[H]is mother, his aunt, and many of the great lords of the Kingdom who attended him,' wrote a biographer of the Jesuits, 'left no stone unturned to discredit the Fathers and their teaching.' It was further noted that 'his bevy of wives followed their example; for they realised that all of them, save one only, would be abandoned if the King became a Christian'. The ladies, who were all dearly devoted to Salim, perhaps also feared and resented the growing influence the Jesuits appeared to have on the young prince. Many decades later Jahangir would recount an incident from this time concerning Acquaviva, 'whose intimate friend he had been'. He described how he came upon the priest when he was scourging himself, for Salim had been sleeping close enough to the Jesuit's quarters to have been disturbed by the sound of the thudding whip. When Salim entered Acquaviva's room, he found a whip 'so covered with blood that drops were falling on the floor' and when questioned, Acquaviva 'tried to cover with a laugh what the flush on his face and the modesty of his eyes plainly betrayed'. Salim was astounded both by the self-denial and flagellation as well as the modesty of the Jesuit who tried to hide the bloodied whip but the ladies, it may be supposed, would have been more leery about this threatening friendship.

In the end the Jesuits were finally undone by Akbar himself who, they admitted, 'was always pondering in his mind which nation has retained the true religion of God; and to this question he constantly gave the most earnest thought'. At the end of one of their last discussions in the ibadat khana Akbar told the assembled scholars and courtiers:

> I perceive that there are varying customs and beliefs of varying religious paths. For the teachings of the Hindus, the Musalmans, the Jazdini, the Jews and the Christians are all different. But the followers of each religion regard the institutions of their own religion as better that those of any other. Not only so, but they strive to convert the rest to their own way of belief. If these refuse to be converted, they not only despise them but also regard them for this very reason as their enemies. And this causes me to feel many serious doubts and scruples.